the provinces on the Baluchi and Afghan frontiers…It is towards such conditions that Reza Khan appears to be aiming. If in the efforts to obtain his objective, he occasionally falls foul of some minor British interest, it may be that at times it will be worth our while to give way…[31]

It was also quickly apparent that Reza Khan was just as determined to prevent a Bolshevik ascendancy over Persian politics as he was to remove any overt British influence. In a conversation with Loraine, Reza Khan explained his purpose was to do what the British had wanted to do themselves, namely to create a strong army, restore order and create a stable and independent Persia.[32] As one historian explains, 'Loraine backed Reza as a man who could achieve order in Iran and thus further British interests'.[33]

Above all, Reza Khan appeared to be a pragmatist. On a number of occasions he was to insist that he was not pro-Bolshevik as some accused him of being, since Bolshevism was ultimately incompatible with Islam.[34] Indeed, by early 1922 the war minister was complaining of the Communist activities of the Soviet legation in Tehran which he felt were destabilising Persian society.[35] Nonetheless, he was convinced that Persia could not afford to irritate its powerful neighbour, or to give the Bolsheviks any pretext for intensifying their activities. As Loraine explained, the Persians 'evidently suppose that Russia may at any moment recover her power, and, mindful of Persia's former sufferings at the hands of her northern neighbour, they anticipate...a swift vengeance'.[36] It is sometimes easy to forget that the period of the Great Game had left its impression not only on the minds of British officials but on Persians' as well.

A key factor of the Great Game is that Britain and Russia's competitiveness had ultimately prevented Persia from being absorbed by either nation. Indeed, prior to 1907 Persia had always looked upon Britain as its guardian in the face of Russian aggression. In Loraine's opinion, even the Anglo-Persian Agreement of 1919 had actually been viewed by some Persians as British protection of Persia against Russia. The Enzeli landings had quickly changed this.[37] However, even now in 1922, as relations with the Bolshevik